

Thank You, Elaine



There was a time I thought this chapter would never exist.

Because writing "thank you" felt too close to saying goodbye.

And I wasn't ready for goodbye.

Now I understand something different.

Gratitude doesn't erase grief.

It simply learns to sit beside it.

So...

before I close this part of my story...

there are a few things I want to say.

Not because I expect you to read them.

Not because I hope they'll change anything.

But because they deserve to exist somewhere.

Even if only inside these pages.



Thank you...

for replying to a stranger.

You had no idea that one ordinary conversation would become one of the most meaningful chapters of my life.

Neither did I.

If either of us had known how much those fifteen days would matter...

I wonder if we would've held them a little more gently.



Thank you...

for letting me see your world.

For introducing me to your children.

For trusting me enough to let me imagine becoming part of your family.

That wasn't something I ever took lightly.

Even now...

I still think it was one of the greatest privileges I've ever been given.



Thank you...

for every random conversation.

Every "good morning."

Every coffee.

Every joke that made absolutely no sense to anyone except us.

Life isn't remembered through milestones alone.

It's remembered through ordinary afternoons that quietly become unforgettable.

You gave me many of those.



Thank you...

for making me dream again.

Before meeting you, I had already accepted a smaller version of my future.

Work.

Games.

Existing.

Then suddenly...

there were apartments.

Christmas.

Rings.

School supplies.

Family dinners.

A little girl running toward me.

You reminded me that somewhere inside me...

hope was still alive.

Even if that future never arrived...

I'm grateful I got to believe in it.



Thank you...

for showing me the kind of man I already was.

For years I wondered if I was capable of loving someone deeply.

You answered that question without ever trying.

I learned that I notice little things.

I remember details.

I plan.

I care.

I love with my whole heart.

Those weren't things you gave me.

They were things you helped me discover.

I'll carry them long after this chapter ends.



Thank you...

for the lessons you never intended to teach.

Because of you...

I learned that compromise isn't losing yourself.

That love asks for sacrifice...

but never asks you to set yourself aside.

I learned that healing isn't forgetting.

It's remembering without falling apart.

I learned that memories are places to visit...

not places to live.

Most importantly...

I learned that loving someone completely doesn't guarantee they'll stay.

And that doesn't make the love any less real.



There are still things I'll never know.

Questions that probably don't need answers anymore.

I've stopped trying to fill those empty spaces with guesses.

Some pages in life remain unfinished.

That's okay.

Not every story needs every sentence explained.

Sometimes...

the ending is simply the ending.



If someday our paths cross again...

I hope we smile.

Not because we forgot.

Because we remembered kindly.

I hope your children are happy.

I hope your dreams came true.

I hope life became gentle with you.

And I hope that somewhere, in one quiet corner of your memory...

there's a version of me that still makes you smile for a second before life continues.

That would be enough.

More than enough.



As for me...

I'll be okay.

Not today.

Not tomorrow.

But one ordinary morning...

I'll wake up.

I'll make coffee.

I'll hear a song we used to like.

And instead of asking the universe why things ended...

I'll simply smile.

Because once upon a time...

they happened.



I don't think people come into our lives only to stay.

Some come to change the direction we're walking.

Some come to remind us who we are.

Some come to wake up parts of us that had been asleep for years.

You did all three.

Thank you.

Truly.



This chapter ends here.

Not because you stopped mattering.

Because you've become part of the foundation I'm standing on now.

The story keeps going.

Just...

on different pages.



Be happy.

Take care of yourself.

Take care of those beautiful children.

And thank you...

for fifteen days that were never small.



With love.

Without regret.

And finally...

with peace.

— Ralph.

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